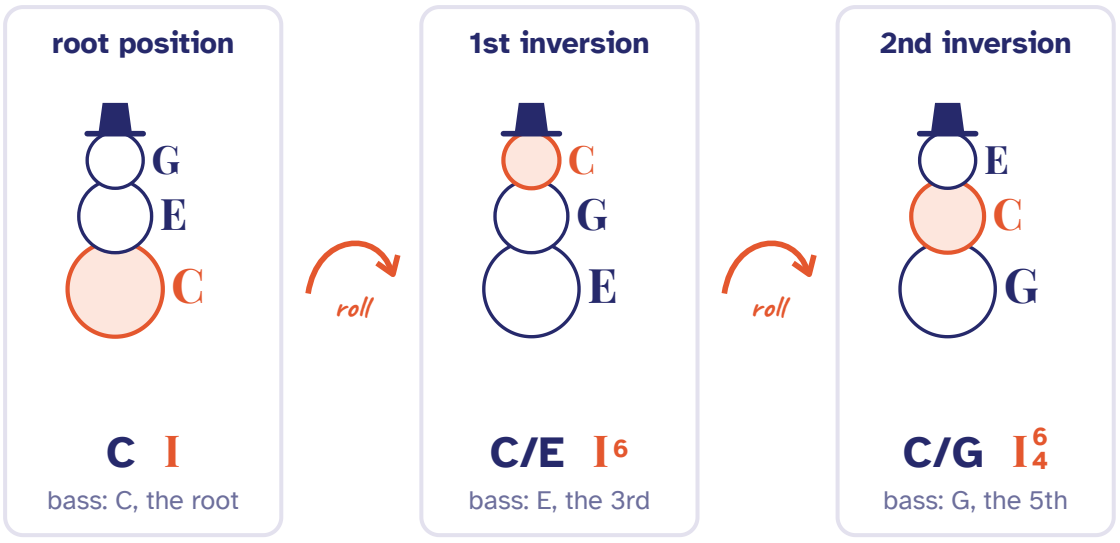
PART IV · HARMONY · 4

Inversions

Same three notes, a different one at the bottom. The chord keeps its name; only the bass changes. The red ball is the root, C: watch it travel.

THE SECRET

Move the bottom note to the top: same chord, new bass.



1. Start with the snowman **C E G**: root at the bottom.
2. Roll the bottom ball to the top: **E G C**. That is the 1st inversion.
3. Roll again: **G C E**, the 2nd inversion. Still **C major**.

Two ways to write it

	ROOT POSITION	1ST INVERSION	2ND INVERSION
Chord symbol pop, jazz	C	C/E	C/G
Harmony class numerals	I	I^6	I^6_4
Also written	Ia, 5/3	Ib, 6/3	Ic, 6/4
First met	Level ½	Level 3	Level 5

The little numbers count up from the bass. E G C: C is a **6th** above E, so I^6. G C E: E is a 6th and C a **4th** above G, so I^6_4. A slash chord just names the bass: C/E (more on p. 82).



The same three chords on the staff; the red note is the root, C. To find the root, restack the notes every other letter (like C E G): then the bottom ball is the root.

PART IV · HARMONY · 4 · CONTINUED

Why inversions?

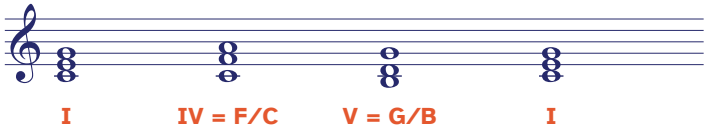
They let your hand **move as little as possible**: keep any note two chords share, and move the others to the nearest note of the next chord. Left-hand accompaniments and hymn parts are written this way.

Chords of C, every position

CHORD	ROOT POSITION	1ST INVERSION	2ND INVERSION
I (C)	C E G	E G C	G C E
IV (F)	F A C	A C F	C F A
V (G)	G B D	B D G	D G B
vi (Am)	A C E	C E A	E A C

EXAMPLE

Play I, IV, V, I smoothly



1. **I:** C E G. **IV:** keep C, move E up to F and G up to A: C F A.
2. **V:** no shared note. C steps down to B, F down to D, A down to G: B D G.
3. **I again:** B up to C, D up to E, G stays: C E G.

IV is F/C and V is G/B: **inversions** keep the hand in one place.

YOU KNOW THIS

Pachelbel's Canon, the bass (here in C)



The famous bass walks **straight down the scale**: C B A G F E. It can, because some chords are **inversions**: G/B, Em/G and C/E put a different note in the bass.

Try it. Play the bass slowly and hum the famous violin tune over it.

THINK OF IT The same three friends in a photo, swapping places: still the same group (the same chord), but whoever stands at the front (the bass) changes the picture.

TRAP

- × Naming a chord from its bass note: in an inversion the bass is not the root. Restack it in 3rds first.
- × Thinking an inversion is a new chord: E G C is still C major.

SEE ALSO

Chords and triads p. 67 · Chords in a key p. 72 · Cadences p. 87

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 4 · Online: Library › Chords